

Culture as Democratic Infrastructure

Participatory Practice and Culture as a Public Right

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Introduction

Culture is usually filed, in budgets and in conversation alike, under amenity: the thing a city affords once its harder infrastructure is paid for. This essay argues the opposite. Culture, when it is participatory and locally rooted, functions as infrastructure in the strict sense — a system that other systems depend on. Roads carry traffic; culture carries the capacity of a society to hold disagreement without breaking. Drawing on four projects delivered between 2021 and 2024 — **Rassif**, **SMASH**, **MIRETAGE**, and **Beyond Gender** — this paper makes the case that democracy is not primarily threatened by the presence of conflict. It is threatened by the absence of spaces built to hold that conflict, metabolise it, and turn it into something workable.

None of these four projects were designed as civic infrastructure. On paper, they were a forum-theatre process with young migrants, a media-literacy programme against online hate speech, a heritage-mapping initiative with religious minorities, and an intergenerational workshop series on gender. What they shared was not a theme but a mechanism: each one took a form of social friction that institutions routinely defer, suppress, or mishandle, and gave it a structured, creative space in which to be expressed, witnessed, and worked through by the people actually living it.

The Argument in One Sentence

Democracy does not weaken because conflict exists. It weakens when a society stops creating spaces capable of holding conflict, listening to it, and converting it into collective action. Participatory cultural practice is one of the few tools built precisely for that job, and it is chronically underfunded relative to the role it plays.

Rassif — Testimony as Authorship

Rassif worked with young migrants, some still minors, others recently turned eighteen, who had crossed into Europe under extreme conditions. The process built toward a forum-theatre piece constructed from their own migratory experiences: bureaucratic barriers, institutional misunderstanding, social invisibility. Audiences were not passive. They could stop the scene, step into it, and test alternative responses collectively, in real time.

At a public performance at Universitat Ramon Llull — Blanquerna, students of similar age to the performers encountered realities far removed from their own. What changed was not the facts of the migrants' situation; those facts were already public, in some form, in policy documents and news coverage. What changed was position. Young people whom institutions habitually process as cases or files stood on a stage as the authors of their own account. Testimony became authorship, and the room had to reckon with a version of events it could not file away as statistics.

SMASH — Inhabiting the Feed Differently

SMASH was a two-year Erasmus+ project against online hate speech, built around twenty sessions that combined digital literacy with artistic production, under the DigiComp framework for critical digital competence. The first half of the process was analytical: participants took apart the architecture of online ecosystems — algorithmic amplification, comment-thread escalation, performed outrage — the mechanics that turn disagreement into spectacle.

The second half was productive. Counter-narratives, counter-memes, and theatrical explorations of digital hostility replaced analysis with authorship. The goal was never to get young people to leave social platforms, nor to moralise about online behaviour from the outside. It was to cultivate a different way of inhabiting the same feeds — one where the mechanics of amplification are visible enough to be resisted, and where the response to hostility is production rather than withdrawal or escalation.

MIRETAGE — Ritual Knowledge as Common Ground

MIRETAGE brought together members of three religious communities — Jewish, Protestant, and Muslim — to explore intangible religious heritage through participatory methods. The stated output was three co-designed heritage routes. The route maps, in the end, mattered less than what produced them: an exchange of memory and ritual knowledge across traditions that, in ordinary civic life, rarely narrate themselves to one another directly.

Through objects, sounds, gestures, and personal stories, participants shared practices that are seldom discussed outside their own communities, let alone across them. The project did not attempt to resolve theological difference or produce a synthetic, shared belief. It built a container — sensory, specific, unhurried — in which difference could be described accurately by the people who live it, rather than paraphrased by outsiders. That container is itself a piece of civic infrastructure: a working method for encountering a minority tradition without asking it to explain itself defensively.

Beyond Gender — Holding Friction Without Resolving It

Beyond Gender worked with older and younger women, first in separate generational groups, then in joint encounter. The tensions were explicit, not smoothed over for the sake of programme optics. Some older participants held that today's social conflicts trace back to failures in upbringing; younger participants reacted defensively. Arts-based methodology did not suppress that friction. It gave it a shared creative frame sturdy enough to hold it without either side walking out.

The objective, deliberately, was not harmony. It was navigability — the capacity of two positions that disagree, sometimes sharply, to remain in the same room, in the same process, long enough to recognise each other as legitimate interlocutors rather than opponents to be defeated. That is a modest outcome by the standards of a communiqué, and a significant one by the standards of a functioning public sphere.

A Shared Method, Not a Shared Theme

Migration, online hate speech, interfaith heritage, and intergenerational gender conflict are not the same subject. What Rassif, SMASH, MIRETAGE, and Beyond Gender share is a production logic: identify a friction institutions tend to defer or flatten; build a structured space, with real facilitation and real time, for the people carrying that friction to name it in their own terms; and treat the resulting testimony, artwork, or route as legitimate civic output — not as therapy, not as outreach, but as material that the wider public sphere has to take seriously.

That logic requires production in the fullest sense: someone has to turn an intuition into a project, a conversation into a partnership, an idea into a budget, a schedule, a team, and finally a shared, public experience. Facilitation without production stays in the room. Production without facilitation produces an event with nothing real inside it. The four projects above worked because both functions were treated as inseparable parts of the same job.

Why This Counts as Infrastructure

Infrastructure is what a system relies on without noticing, until it is missing. Democratic systems rely on a population's capacity to disagree without disintegrating: to hear an opposing account, sit with the discomfort it produces, and still show up to the next negotiation. That capacity is not innate, and it is not maintained automatically. It is built, session by session, through practices that give conflict a structured place to happen — which is precisely what forum theatre, participatory heritage mapping, and facilitated intergenerational dialogue are designed to do.

When that infrastructure is absent, conflict does not disappear. It moves to less structured, less accountable spaces — anonymous comment threads, closed-off communities, silence that eventually curdles into resentment. The four projects discussed here are small relative to the scale of that problem. But they are evidence of a repeatable model, not one-off exceptions, and repeatable models are exactly what infrastructure investment is supposed to fund.

Conclusion

None of this argues that culture should be protected from scrutiny or measured differently from any other public investment. It argues the opposite: that participatory cultural practice should be evaluated, funded, and staffed with the seriousness given to infrastructure, because functionally that is what it is. A society that keeps building roads while letting the spaces that hold its disagreements quietly disappear is not choosing efficiency. It is choosing to let conflict find its own, worse channels. Rassif, SMASH, MIRETAGE, and Beyond Gender suggest a better channel already exists, is affordable, and works. It only needs to be treated as what it is.